

An Unfinished Symphony: Completing the Playbook for Reading Education



Why researchers, teachers, and writers now argue America's reading crisis is a **professionalization problem — not a knowledge one.**

For many, the Science of Reading movement has entered its 'trough of despair'. Not only are nationwide scores not up; they are, in fact, down. Finger-pointing has begun. "Too much phonics". "Not enough whole books." "Time wasted on phonemic awareness." "MTSS doesn't work."

The uncomfortable truth is that structured literacy suffers from the same confusion as "balanced literacy". It remains — in its fine-grained elements — under-defined.¹

The problem shifts: Enabling pervasive good practices

For decades, reading reform centered on getting evidence-aligned instruction into more than a minority of classrooms.

By 2023, Mark Seidenberg was pressing a different question: now that demand for the science of reading had grown, where was the expertise and infrastructure needed to turn a large, changing research base into dependable practice? Teachers should not have to become cognitive scientists; the science has to be built into the systems around them.

By mid-2026, calls for system integration solutions had appeared from a variety of experts. A panel with Doug Carnine, Sarah Oberle, Mike Schmoker, and Robert Pondiscio offers a video synopsis of these.¹¹

In Congress, legislation for an NRP 2.0 has passed out of the Appropriations Committee. If it becomes law, will this solve the problem at hand?

At the scale of millions of teachers and thousands of intermediaries, messages drift as they propagate. Would NRP 2.0 adequately address this?

40% of U.S. fourth-graders read below NAEP Basic in 2024.

Black fourth-graders face massive, systemic hurdles in reading.

From awareness to consistency

2023 · SEIDENBERG^{2,3} The science has won attention, but research expertise is thin throughout the education system. Translation and professional infrastructure are missing.

2024-25 · JONES^{4,6} A living profession needs "garbage collection"; other professions have solutions that can help cut instructional waste, reduce opportunity costs, help kids read.

2024-26 · CALLS FOR NRP 2.0^{5,7,8} In the wake of unsustainable and unscaled improvement, calls grow for a new National Reading Panel to synthesize research done since NRP I.

2025-26 · CARNINE/LYON^{9,10,11,12,15} frame the problem as professionalization: shared knowledge, common language, aligned preparation, competence-based licensure, accountability.

2026 · TIPTON/PATTON-TERRY¹³ Beyond the science of reading, we need an "engineering of reading."

THE BEGINNINGS OF PROFESSIONAL INFRASTRUCTURE

The pieces steadily come online

Reading education has begun to acquire much-needed tools and structures.

The Reading League: standards for foundational curricula¹⁴

Its Curriculum Evaluation Guidelines and Navigation Reports help schools make better choices.

Reading Rockets + Reading Universe^{16,17}

Reading Rockets has been refurbished and updated; Reading Universe adds a newer, practical, video-rich body of guidance.

State-built professional learning^{18,19}

States are increasingly building grade-, role-, and context-specific training, administrator pathways, and refresher modules.

UFLI brings a free, quality phonics program, with training.

Scope and sequence, routines, assessments, videos, fidelity tools, and implementation supports package research.

State-Coordinated Coaching Networks²⁰

While 26 states have adopted some form of coaching policies, 8 have the type of coordinated field force that brought Mississippi its gains.

ExcellinEd: 18 Early Literacy Fundamental Principles³⁰

A state policy blueprint: screening, parent notification, teacher support, intervention, and retention as a last resort.

Learning Science Practices | ResearchEd

Led by our friends in the UK, teachers are tying day to day teaching to learning science well beyond structured literacy.

Fixing the Ed Schools: Teacher-prep standards and audits^{21,22}

NCTQ's systematic reviews of teacher-preparation programs has led to state audits and standards for schools of education.

Knowledge Matters: supporting knowledge-building²³

The Knowledge Matters Campaign focuses on the critical role of knowledge-building in early literacy, and on approaches to do so.

Johns Hopkins ELA Knowledge Map²⁴

With the ELA Knowledge Map, reviewers can explore the domains, sequencing, coherence, and gaps in a curriculum's content knowledge.

The EdReports reckoning^{25,26}

The exposure of serious weaknesses in the Ed Reports definition of "evidence-based" has led it to release a "2.0 Review Criteria", and to users being far more circumspect about its ratings.

Podcasts and specialist media: solid learning²⁷

A strong ecosystem of podcast series and specialist videos now lets those with the inclination learn on their own schedule.

Social-Media Dispersal and Discussion

The Facebook Group Science of Reading—What I Should Have Learned in College now has 250,000 members. An extremely well-informed X community daily discusses the hard cases of Structured Literacy. Substack gives longer-form ideas immediate feedback.

R&D and Systems for older readers, too^{28,29}

From more structured fifth-grade word study to systems for severe high school remediation; from individually-authored programs to high end programs like Reading Reimagined, all K12 literacy is getting love.

Building Consistent Nationwide Teaching Capability

No one should doubt the remarkable success represented in the above components. Few, indeed, would have had reason to expect us to have come so far, so fast.

Still Missing

Yet there remains missing an integrating framework. A unifying structure that ties together the various components of the system.

The Gaps — A Case Study

Is Reading Universe a suitable knowledge base? It would appear so: it explains phonemic awareness, decoding, fluency, vocabulary, morphology, and many classroom routines quite well.

Yet critical components are missing: Knowledge-building is not developed as a major segment. Fine-grained issues such as morphophonemic alternation in complex multisyllabic words receive little treatment. Poor practices like teaching “blends” remain.

Further, research traceability is inconsistent and not built into the architecture. It lacks the maintenance, issue tracking, version control, and feedback processes critical to the profession.

Four Approaches

NRP 2.0

While some argue for a new National Reading Panel^{7,8}, the truth is that experts have long been monitoring, and sharing the updated research. A government-sponsored panel of experts may seem a viable next step. Yet there are better ways to achieve what’s needed.

An ‘Engineering of Reading’

It’s a good phrase: an engineering mindset is definitely needed. Today we have more of a writers + publishers mentality driving the system - extremely useful, yet insufficient to the need.

On the other hand, engineering-like documents can only be intermidate steps. Not teacher- or trainer-facing work products. The various engineering professions are all smaller, and generally draw from a more academically elite demographic base than teaching. Where they can suffer more technical jargon, the teaching profession cannot.

A Field Manual System

Here, the focus is on the median teacher (with various ‘extra duties’, a supplemental coaching contract, 3 kids at home, maybe a parent needing care).³¹

Part natural ‘Field guide’ (describing nature); part field manual (describing a working system and default operating procedures), not just print, but a science-backed collection of the best all-media resources for learning structured literacy.

Field manuals are something much more than a mere book published by one or two authors, and far more than the standard blog post, video, or podcast episode (not that those don’t serve!), and more than a website of independently authored white papers.³²

They are a snapshot of the institution’s understanding of best practices: grade-by-grade scope and sequence, explicit routines, decision rules for common classroom situations, diagnostic and progress-monitoring tools, and checklists.

More than that, they are created not just to publish information, but to teach it. They are designed for people who are not first and foremost knowledge workers. They are written with the objective of being read by (in Pondiscio’s words) mere mortals.

They not only explain the research base; they use learning science and instructional principles in their own design for teacher/trainer learning.

A Community-Maintained Canonical Source

Teaching, in the US, is a far larger, and more decentralized profession than most. It has no clear institutional center. Thus, while the US military is a similarly-sized profession, and the US Army’s doctrine and manual system provides a solid model for a knowledge center, reading education has no TRADOC equivalent to organize and maintain such a canonical source.

There is, tho, a similarly-sized profession, with similarly decentralized leadership. And they have solved this challenge.

For thirty years, communities of open source software developers have collaboratively built not just products, but documentation and all manner of tools to support the open source processes.

In time, a unique culture also developed, to support those people, methods, and tools. Habits of mind actually changed to support the new model.

Reading education can import that culture and process.

Processes. Named maintainers, contribution rules, issue tracking, version control, review cycles, tests, release histories.

Culture. Contribute, don’t complain. Many eyes make bugs shallow. Being specifically wrong beats being right and vague.

The resulting knowledge base is more reliable precisely because many capable people can inspect it, challenge it, and improve it — without any one organization holding all the expertise.

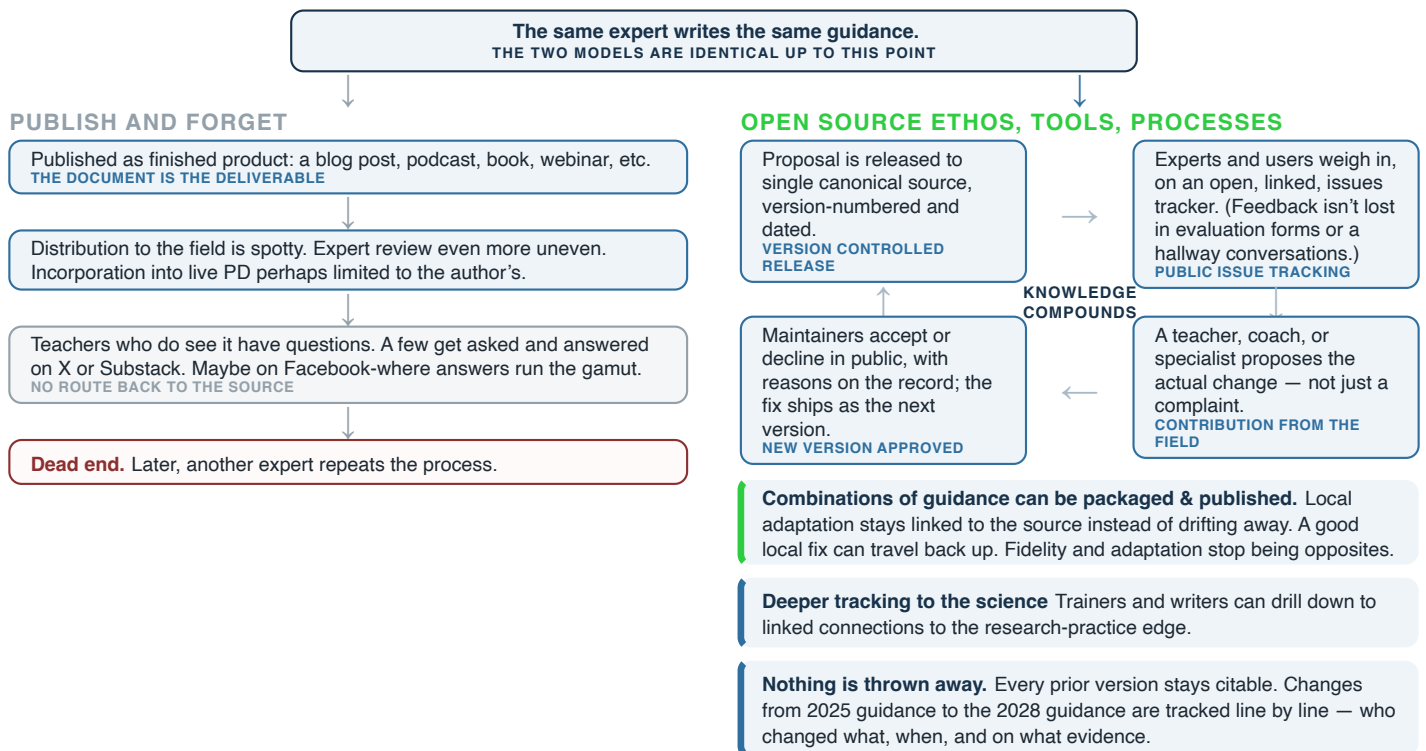
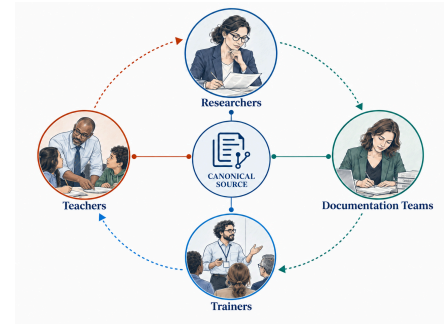
Moving Past Publish & Forget:

Bringing in Teachers & Trainers; Accelerating the Speed of the Loop

The difference between the two models is not the document. It is whether anything happens after the document ships.

Let's look at some details of practice:

- After K-1 MOY assessments, many teachers are unsure of what to do with the data.
- A decision tree is needed. It will look different for different grades, and assessment products.
- A true expert in the field creates one, and it seems good. It considers changes to Tier I instruction, using additional diagnostics, arranging Tier II intervention, and more.



In the publish-and-forget model, improvement comes in random acts of innovation. In an open source community, improvement is constant and *cumulative*: the thousands of corrections teachers already make in private become one shared, reviewed, attributed asset.

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Where Structured Literacy Guidance Can Drift

Even when teachers are committed to structured literacy, unclear, inherited, or weakly specified guidance can cause instruction to drift. The problem is often not grossly bad practice. It is the accumulation of small decisions that consume time, attention, and working memory without producing proportional gains.

PHONEMIC AWARENESS AND PHONICS

Treating consonant blends as though they were new sound-symbol correspondences.

A student who can read /s/ /t/ /ð/ /p/ already possesses the correspondences needed for *stop*. Extra instructional categories such as *st-*, *bl-*, *tr-* may sometimes help with blending difficulty, but they can also become an entire layer of phonics content without clear evidence that the category itself needs to be taught.

Overtaching phonemic manipulation after basic decoding is established.

Deleting the second sound in *smile*, reversing phonemes, or performing increasingly elaborate oral-only tasks may continue long after a student can segment, blend, and map phonemes to print. What begins as useful preparation for decoding can become a detached exercise with diminishing transfer to reading.

Teaching syllable division as a rule system rather than a flexible aid.

Students may spend substantial time marking VCCV, VCV, VC/CV, or similar patterns as if the divisions determine pronunciation. In actual words, stress, morphology, vowel flexibility, and lexical knowledge often matter more. The routine can become more elaborate than the reading problem it is supposed to solve.

Treating six syllable types as a decoding algorithm.

Open, closed, vowel-consonant-e, r-controlled, vowel-team, and consonant-le categories can be useful descriptions. Problems arise when students are expected to classify syllables first and read words second, or when exceptions force increasingly complicated rules.

MORPHOLOGY AND ORTHOGRAPHY

Ignoring morphology until students are considered “advanced.”

A student may be taught to attack *unhelpfulness*, *disagreement*, or *reconstruction* primarily through syllabification even though meaningful units provide a clearer structure. Delaying morphology can make complex words unnecessarily difficult.

Introducing morphology as lists of prefixes and suffixes.

The opposite error also occurs. Students memorize *pre-*, *re-*, *un-*, *-ful*, *-tion* without learning how morphological structure explains meaning, spelling, word families, or pronunciation changes.

Failing to teach morphophonemic change.

Pairs such as *define/definition*, *sign/signature*, *serene/serenity*, and *electric/electricity* reveal why English spelling cannot be understood solely as sound-to-letter matching. Without this knowledge, teachers may describe perfectly regular morphological spellings as exceptions students simply have to remember.

Using “schwa” as an explanation rather than teaching what causes it.

Students may be told that an unstressed vowel “says /uh/” without learning the role of stress, morphology, and word structure. The label names the phenomenon but does not necessarily help them read or spell the word.

Continuing to teach every irregular word as a heart word.

Words may be treated as visually irregular even when most of their spelling is phonically or morphologically explainable. The result can be unnecessary memorization and lost opportunities to strengthen the orthographic system students are learning.

Marking too many word parts as “irregular.”

When a pronunciation does not match an introductory phonics rule, the mismatch may reflect stress, historical spelling, morphology, or a more advanced correspondence. Calling each case an exception can make English look less systematic than it is.

TEXT SELECTION

Equating decodability with instructional suitability.

A text can technically conform to taught correspondences and still impose awkward syntax, weak vocabulary, low coherence, or excessive cognitive load. Conversely, excluding every word containing an untaught pattern can impoverish language and knowledge unnecessarily.

Using controlled text for too long.

Decodable text can be valuable while students consolidate the alphabetic system. If tightly controlled text persists after students can handle broader print, it may constrain vocabulary, syntax, fluency, and knowledge building.

Moving students out of controlled text too early.

The reverse error leaves students guessing from context because the text contains too many patterns they cannot yet decode reliably. “Authentic text” is not automatically appropriate text.

FLUENCY

Treating oral reading fluency as a single problem.

A low words-correct-per-minute score can result from inaccurate decoding, weak automaticity, difficulty with multisyllabic words, poor phrasing, limited vocabulary, or unfamiliar content. Repeated reading is not an equally appropriate response to all of them.

Using repeated reading when the bottleneck is decoding.

A student can become faster at a practiced passage without acquiring the word-reading knowledge needed to transfer that improvement to a new passage.

Using decoding practice when the bottleneck is language comprehension.

A student may read every word accurately and still fail to understand the sentence because of vocabulary, syntax, background knowledge, pronoun reference, or logical relationships.

Calling an accurate but slow reader a “fluency problem” without locating the source.

Slow performance may reflect inefficient word recognition, excessive decoding effort, unfamiliar morphology, limited exposure to print, or language difficulty. The label does not identify the instructional target.

VOCABULARY, KNOWLEDGE, AND COMPREHENSION

Teaching vocabulary as isolated definitions.

Students may copy definitions, match words to meanings, or memorize weekly lists without learning semantic relationships, morphology, multiple meanings, collocations, or the knowledge domain in which the words are useful.

Treating background knowledge as a comprehension strategy.

Students cannot “activate” knowledge they do not possess. Asking what they already know is not a substitute for systematically building knowledge over months and years.

Teaching comprehension through strategy rehearsal after the strategy is understood.

Predicting, questioning, summarizing, and identifying main ideas can help students learn how comprehension works. Repeatedly practicing the same strategies can displace the acquisition of vocabulary and knowledge that increasingly drives comprehension.

Teaching “main idea” as though it were independent of knowledge.

Students may be asked to infer main ideas from passages about topics they barely understand, making a knowledge deficit look like a strategy deficit.

Underteaching sentence structure.

Students who know every word in a sentence may still misunderstand passive voice, embedded clauses, nominalizations, conjunctions, or pronoun references. Vocabulary instruction alone will not repair a syntactic problem.

Overtaching grammatical labels.

Students can spend substantial time naming predicates, subordinating conjunctions, or clause types without becoming better at understanding or constructing difficult sentences. The instructional question is whether the grammatical knowledge supports reading and writing.

PROGRAMS, ASSESSMENT, AND INTERVENTION

Assuming a program scope and sequence is the same thing as a knowledge model.

A commercial program necessarily makes sequencing choices. Those choices may be sensible, but teachers can begin treating one program’s terminology, order, and routines as though they represented settled findings about reading development.

Treating fidelity as immunity from error.

Implementation fidelity is useful only if the underlying practice is well matched to the student and the evidence. Perfectly implementing the wrong response simply produces consistent inefficiency.

Adding interventions instead of subtracting ineffective instruction.

A struggling student may receive core instruction plus phonemic awareness intervention plus phonics intervention plus fluency practice plus software. The result can be a day dominated by remediation while the actual bottleneck remains unidentified.

Responding to every error with immediate correction.

Constant interruption can reduce fluency and comprehension. On the other hand, allowing repeated decoding errors to pass can reinforce faulty word recognition. Teachers need clearer guidance about which errors matter, when to interrupt, and why.

Treating every student below benchmark as needing the same foundational-skills sequence.

Two students with the same screening score may have very different causes: weak phoneme-grapheme knowledge, slow automatic recognition, language disorder, limited vocabulary, poor attendance, or little experience with English print. A benchmark is a signal, not a diagnosis.

Continuing instruction because it is “evidence based” without checking response.

Population-level evidence does not guarantee that a particular routine remains useful for a particular student. Instruction should change when progress data show that the presumed mechanism is not producing the expected result.

Each of these is an open issue, not a verdict. In a community-maintained canonical source, every item above would be a tracked issue: evidence linked, objections on the record, and guidance revised in the next version rather than left to drift.